Dalit (formerly known as untouchables) at the bottom. Professions, tools and everyday activities have also been classified by their level of purity, and strict rules have forbidden ‘impure’ persons to marry ‘pure’ people, touch them, prepare food for them or even come near them.

The modern state of India still struggles with this legacy, which influences almost all aspects of life. For example, fears of impurity created various complications for the aforementioned Clean India Mission, because allegedly ‘pure’ people were reluctant to get involved in ‘impure’ activities such as building, maintaining and cleaning toilets, or to share public latrines with allegedly ‘impure’ persons.[43] On 25 September 2019, two Dalit children – twelve-year-old Roshni Valmiki and her ten-year-old nephew Avinash – were lynched in the Indian village of Bhakhedi for defecating near the house of a family from the higher Yadav caste. They were forced to defecate in public because their houses lacked functioning toilets. A local official later explained that their household – while being among the poorest in the village – was nevertheless excluded from the list of families eligible for government aid to build toilets. The children routinely suffered from other caste-based discrimination, for example being forced to bring separate mats and utensils to school and to sit apart from the other pupils, so as not to ‘pollute’ them.[44]

The list of biological dramas that press our emotional buttons includes several additional classics, such as ‘Who will be alpha?’ ‘Us versus them’ and ‘Good versus evil’. These dramas, too, feature prominently in the *Ramayana*, and all of them are well known to wolf packs and chimpanzee bands as well as to human societies. Together, these biological dramas form the backbone of almost all human art and mythology. But art’s dependence on biological dramas has made it difficult for artists to explain the mechanisms of bureaucracy. The *Ramayana* is set within the context of large agrarian kingdoms, but it shows little interest in how such kingdoms register property, collect taxes, catalogue archives or finance wars. Sibling rivalry and romantic triangles aren’t a good guide for the dynamics of documents, which have no siblings and no romantic life.

Storytellers like Franz Kafka, who focused on the often surreal ways that bureaucracy shapes human lives, pioneered new nonbiological plotlines. In Kafka’s *The Trial*, the bank clerk K is arrested by unidentified officials of an unfathomable agency for an unnamed crime. Despite his best efforts, he never understands what is happening to him or uncovers the aims of the